

Instructions: Read the passage below and answer ALL questions

How TikTok Is Rewriting the World

- 1 “Fear of missing out” is a common way to describe how social media can 1
make people feel like everyone else is part of something that they’re not. A new
wrinkle in this concept is that sometimes that “something” is a social media
platform itself. You might have seen a photo of friends at a great party on Instagram
and felt left out. Then, a strange TikTok video appeared in your feed—watermarked, 5
set to an unfamiliar song, featuring an unknown person, or perhaps you noticed
TikTok ads everywhere and wondered why that world felt so distant.
- 2 It’s been a while since a new social app got big enough to make non-users
feel they’re missing out from an experience. Aside from Fortnite, which is social
but still a game, the last app to generate this much curiosity from non-users was 10
probably Snapchat. While you, perhaps an anxious abstainer, may feel perfectly
secure in your “choice” not to join that service, Snapchat has more daily users than
Twitter, which, despite its significant role in social media and news sharing, has
seen a decline in its user base and influence in recent years. Snapchat, on the other
hand, changed the course of its industry and altered the way people communicate 15
with their phones. With 500 million users, TikTok’s intentions aren’t obvious, but
they still exist. TikTok is far from an evolutionary fluke. Its parent company,
ByteDance, recently valued at more than \$75 billion, bills itself first as an artificial
intelligence company, not a creator of mission-driven social platforms.
- 3 TikTok is an app for making and sharing short videos, and it differs from 20
other social apps in terms of format, navigation and hashtags. The videos are tall,
not square, like on Snapchat or Instagram’s stories. Users navigate through videos
by scrolling up and down, like a feed, not by tapping or swiping side to side. When
it comes to editing tools, TikTok offers features similar to those found on other
social apps, giving video creators all sorts of tools at their disposal: filters and the 25
ability to search for sounds to score your video. Users are also encouraged to
interact through response videos or duets, where they can replicate videos and join
in. Hashtags play a surprisingly large role on TikTok. In more innocent times,
Twitter hoped its users might congregate around hashtags, continuously gather in a
never-ending series of productive pop-up mini discourses. On TikTok, hashtags 30
actually exist as a real, functional organising principle: not for news, or even really
anything trending anywhere else than TikTok, but for various TikTok challenges,
jokes, repeating formats or other discernible blobs of activity.
- 4 It’s easy to make a video on TikTok, not just because of the tools it gives
users, but because of extensive reasons and prompts it provides for you. It 35
encourages spontaneous posting by constantly suggesting content to watch and
create. You can select from an enormous range of sounds, from popular song clips
to short moments from TV shows, YouTube videos or TikTok contents. Unlike
Instagram, which emphasises carefully curated and polished content, TikTok
encourages participation through accessible trends and challenges – such as dance 40
memes, humorous skits and dare-like tasks – that require minimal preparation.
TikTok assertively answers anyone’s *what should I watch* with a flood. In the same
way, the app provides plenty of answers for the paralysing *what should I post?* The
result is an endless unspooling of material that young people might be too self-
conscious to post on Instagram. Additionally, some of this endless stream of posts 45
might be ideas or creations they wouldn’t have come up with on their own but were
encouraged or prompted to do so. The never-ending flow of content can be hard to

watch, and it can be charming and funny. This frequently results in both creative and “cringe” content.

5 TikTok can feel, to an American audience, a bit like a greatest hits 50
compilation, featuring only the most engaging elements and experiences of its
predecessors. This is true, to a point, but TikTok must also be understood as one of
the most popular of *many* short-video-sharing apps in that country. This is
a landscape that evolved both alongside and at arm’s length from the American tech
industry. Under the hood, TikTok is a fundamentally different app than American 55
users have used before. It may look and feel like its friend-feed-centric peers, and
you can follow and be followed. Of course, there are hugely popular “stars” as
many cultivated by the company itself. Then, there’s messaging. Users can and do
use it like any other social app, but its various aesthetics, visual design, and
functional similarities to Vine, Snapchat, or Instagram mask a fundamental 60
difference: TikTok is more machine than man. It may appear similar on the surface
but actually hides a key difference underneath.

6 Generally, we often do spend more time with the social media apps as they’ve
become more assertive, and less intimately human, even as we’ve complained.
What’s both crucial and easy to miss about TikTok is how it has stepped over the 65
midpoint between the familiar self-directed feed and an experience based first on
algorithmic observation and inference. The most obvious clue is right there when
you open the app: the first thing you see isn’t a feed of your friends, but a page
called “For You” (FYP). TikTok’s FYP is primarily determined by an algorithm that
analyses videos a user interacts with or watches. Instead of relying on a feed of 70
friends, it continuously suggests content based on user behaviour even without
explicit input. It never runs out of material. It is not, unless you train it to be, full of
people you know, or things you’ve clearly told it you want to see. It’s full of things
that you seem to have demonstrated you want to watch, no matter what you actually
say you want to watch. It is constantly learning from you. Over time, it builds a 75
presumably complex but opaque model of what you tend to watch, shows you more
of that, or related subjects. TikTok starts making assumptions the second you’ve
opened the app, before you’ve really given it anything to work with. Imagine an
Instagram centred entirely around its “Explore” tab, or a Twitter built around
trending topics or viral tweets, with “following” bolted onto the side. Imagine a 80
version of Facebook that was able to fill your feed before you’d friended a single
person. That’s TikTok.

7 Older social apps are continuously evolving, too. Their models prioritise
growth and discovery, of course, but also assume the centrality of your people: the
accounts you follow, those who follow you, and even those you communicate with 85
directly – whether or not you follow them back – all of which are bound up in their
founding myths and structures. TikTok though is the towering stick falling far and
fast, not caring to wait to evolve through a wriggling and cumbersome social phase
where social interaction is awkward, difficult, or inconvenient to navigate. Instead,
TikTok takes the lead and change the typical engagement game with a different 90
approach: Why not show people content and see how they react? Why not
encourage them to create and see what happens? If success is measured by
engagement, why not design the app to maximise time spent on it? There’s no rule
against engagement for its own sake – so let it grow and take over.

Adapted from Herrman, J. (2019). How TikTok Is Rewriting the World? The New York Times.
<https://www.nytimes.com/2019/03/10/style/what-is-tik-tok.html>

PART 1: CONTEXTUAL CLUES (5 MARKS)

Instruction: Provide a word from the reading passage for each definition below.

No	Definition	Paragraph	Answer
<i>Example:</i> 0	not known or recognised	1	unfamiliar
1	a person who chooses not to participate in a particular activity, often by personal choice or principle	2	
2	to gather or come together in a group, crowd, or assembly, usually for a shared purpose	3	
3	the process of something becoming less strong or less under control	4	
4	how things look or are designed	5	
5	difficult to do or manage and taking a lot of time and effort	7	

PART 2: TRUE/FALSE STATEMENT (5 MARKS)

Instruction: Identify each statement below as True (T) or False (F)

1. "Fear of Missing Out" refers to a feeling of contentment and satisfaction when social media users see others participating in activities they are not part of.
2. Creating a video on TikTok is simple, not only due to the available tools but also because of the numerous prompts and ideas it offers users.
3. People spend less time on social media apps as they become less assertive and more intimately human.
4. As soon as you open TikTok, it starts predicting your interests, even before you interact with anything.
5. TikTok allows you to directly communicate only with accounts that you follow and that follow you back.

PART 3: COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS (10 MARKS)

Instructions: Answer all the following comprehension questions

1. What makes TikTok different from previous social apps like Snapchat? (1 mark)
2. How do TikTok, Instagram Stories, and Snapchat differ from each other? (4 marks)
Elaborate your answers.
3. In what ways does TikTok's content recommendation and creation process influence users' posting behaviour and self-expression compared to other social media platforms? (2 marks)
4. a) What is the primary way TikTok determines the content shown on the "For You" page? (1 mark)

b) How does the "For You" page work? (1 mark)
5. What is TikTok's main approach to user engagement? (1 mark)